Adolf Hitler. 20/04/1889 – 30/04/1945

If He Had Been Heard

**My Investigation: How a different childhood could have changed history*

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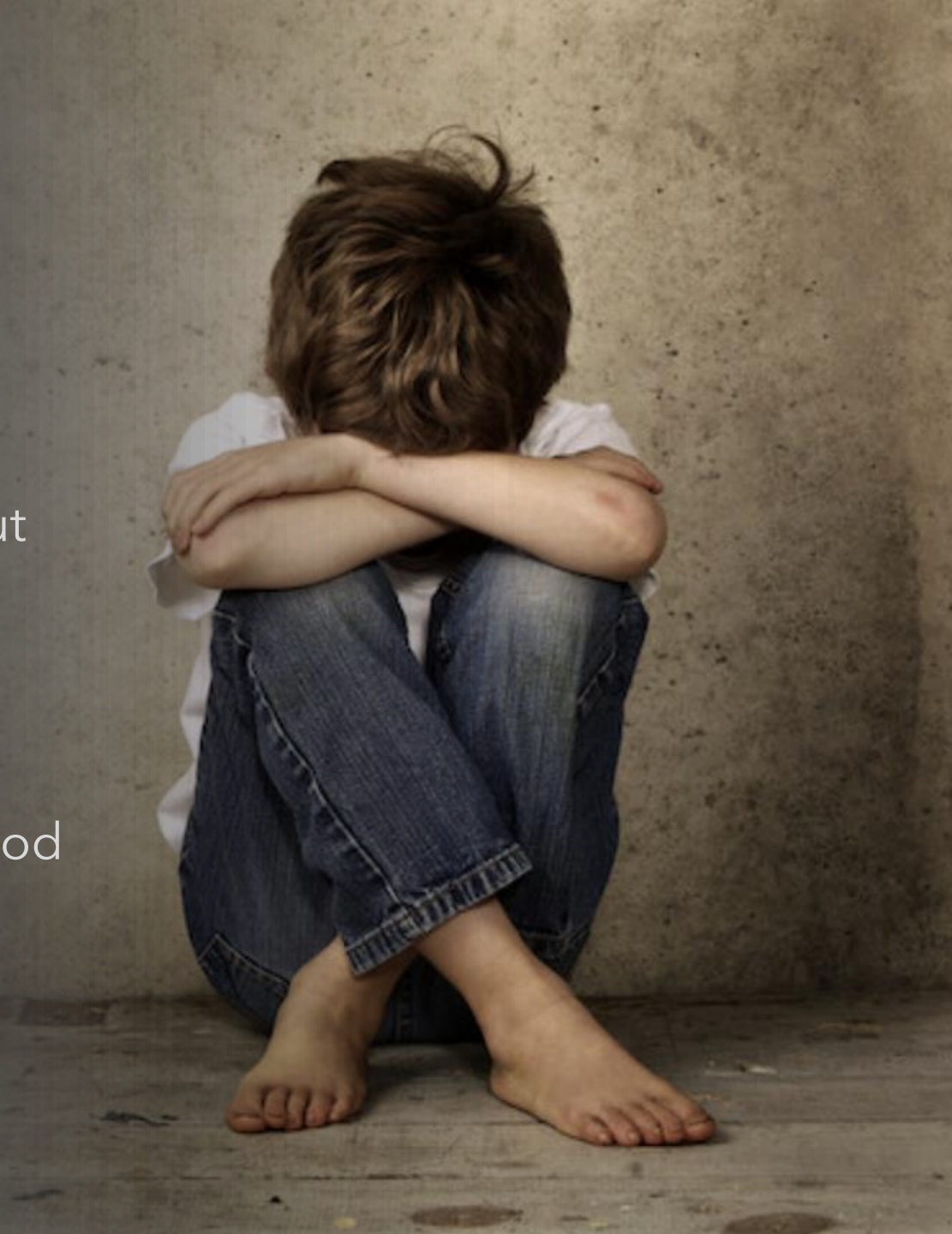
Introduction

Sometimes, I wonder how someone like Adolf Hitler became so full of hate.

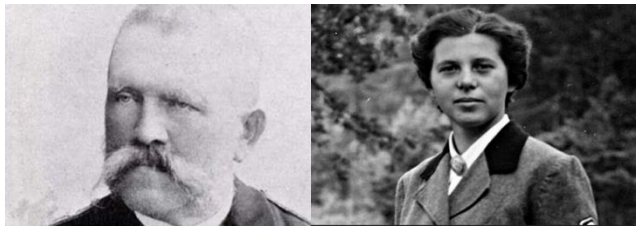
This is not about forgiveness – it's about understanding how early pain becomes danger if no one stops it.

Would a more loving, supportive childhood have led to a different person – and a different history?



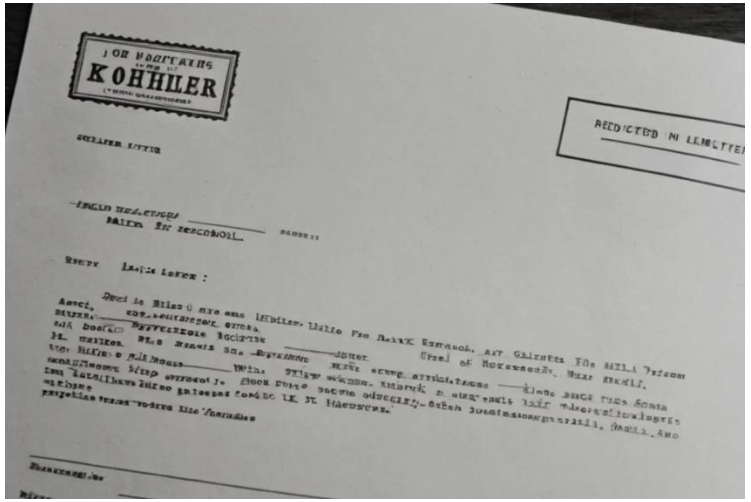
The Child Behind the Monster

(Wilkins, Khera, Moody, 2021)



A painful childhood.
Strict father, tender mother.
Lonely, frightened, unheard.

The turning point.
Hurt turned to hate.
Rejection grew into rage.



A dream rejected.
He wanted to paint — they said no.
His identity collapsed.

What If?

What if his father had been kind?

What if someone had supported his art?

What if he had felt understood and accepted?

Maybe he would have become an architect, or a painter.
Maybe he would have created beauty, not destroyed lives.

(Kraft, 2020)

Good Boy!!

Keep it up!

Admitted

Final Image

Lazy Boy!!

Unacceptable

Rejected

Reflection

Working on both Assessment 2 and Assessment 3 deepened my understanding of how personal history can shape collective history. Focusing on Adolf Hitler's early life, I explored how trauma, neglect, and rejection may have contributed to the emergence of one of history's most destructive figures. Rather than seeking to excuse or humanize him, my goal was to reflect on the emotional roots of hate and the role of unmet needs.

In Assessment 2, my process journal allowed me to investigate historical and psychological sources, highlighting the contrast between Hitler's strict, volatile father and his warm, protective mother (Khera, 2021; Moody, 2021). This duality shaped my concept for the final visual work: to show the boy behind the dictator — quiet, fragile, and unheard. I found the rejection from art school symbolic; it was more than failure — it was identity collapse (Wilkins, 2021).

In Assessment 3, I brought these emotional ideas into a final visual composition. I created GIF images of the real Hitler — showing him first as he truly was mad, cold, and unhappy. Then, using Photoshop, I altered his expression to make him smile — a version of what he might have looked like if he had known joy or peace. This contrast between reality and possibility was powerful. I also added layers of old newspapers to ground the work in history and create a sense of time and loss. The combination of image and question — "What if he had been heard?" — helped me connect history with empathy, not sympathy, but deep emotional understanding.

This experience showed me that visual storytelling can challenge audiences to look deeper than surface narratives. It also reminded me of the importance of mental health support, especially in youth. A neglected child can become a danger to others — or, with kindness, a force for good.

Ultimately, both works reflect my belief: behind every "monster" is a story. If we understand it, we might prevent the next one.

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